



Eggs and babies

Most turtle and tortoise eggs are completely round, like ping-pong balls. Some are hard, but others are quite soft to touch. The babies peck their way out of the eggs.

Tortoises and turtles are born complete with their shells.



Hinge-back tortoise



Hiding on the spot

When a tortoise feels threatened, it quickly pulls its legs and head under its shell, and keeps very still. The shell is too hard for any animal to eat.

Tortoises' shells are made of bone.

Race to the ocean

Turtles return to land to lay eggs – sometimes thousands of them on one beach. When they hatch, the babies all make a rush for the sea where they will live.

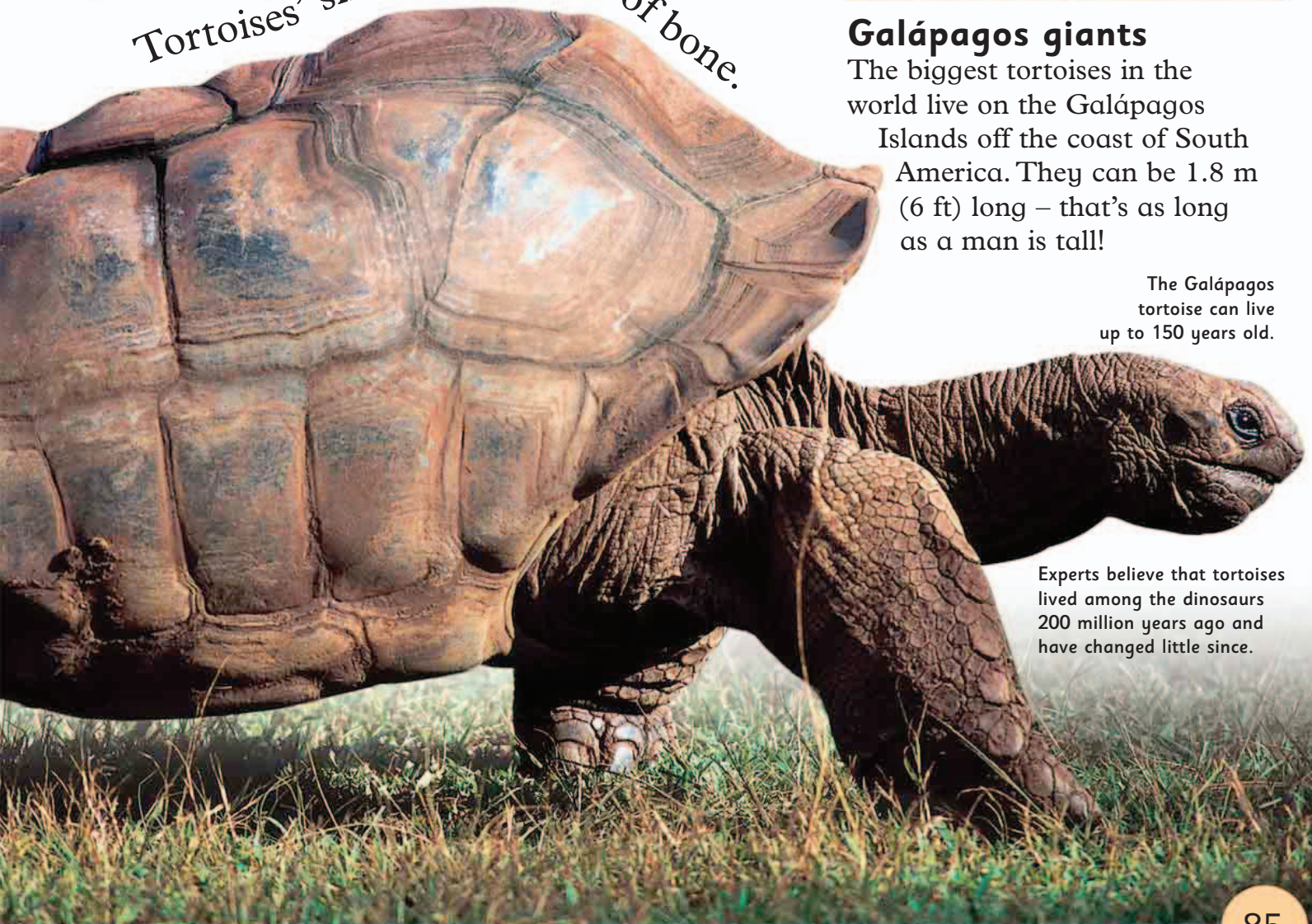


Galápagos giants

The biggest tortoises in the world live on the Galápagos

Islands off the coast of South America. They can be 1.8 m (6 ft) long – that's as long as a man is tall!

The Galápagos tortoise can live up to 150 years old.



Experts believe that tortoises lived among the dinosaurs 200 million years ago and have changed little since.